

8.11

Apologize, explain and offer

Worksheet

Work with a partner. Take turns to be customer and supplier in the phone calls below. The supplier may decide to make a follow-up call.

Ask questions	Have you tried ... (+ <i>ing</i> form of verb)? When did you ...?
Apologize and explain	Really? I'm very sorry, this has never happened before. It's probably just ... We're having a small problem with We're doing everything we can. Our Accounts Department made a small mistake when they processed your order. I really am very sorry.
Offer a solution	No problem. I'll send you a replacement immediately. Can you leave it with me? I'll look into it and get back to you tomorrow.
End the call	I'm sorry again for any inconvenience we have caused. If you have any more problems, please let me know.

Situation 1

Customer: You ordered some expensive items (you decide what). When you opened the package this morning one of them had a fault.

Supplier: You can send a replacement.

Situation 2

Customer: You ordered some software last month. It still hasn't arrived.

Supplier: This new software package has been very popular. You are temporarily out of stock and are waiting for more deliveries.

Situation 3

Customer: You ordered some products (you decide what – it could be the same as Situation 1). They still haven't arrived.

Supplier: This customer has reached his/her credit limit. Your Accounts Department has told you not to send any more products until the customer's last invoice is paid.

Situation 4

Customer: You recently ordered 10,000 T-shirts from a foreign supplier. 5,000 arrived yesterday and the quality is not as good as the original sample.

Supplier: You manufacture cheap T-shirts in a country with low labor costs. Your success is based on price, not quality. You sent the first half of the order last week. The rest will follow soon, but you can't say exactly when. Your factory is very busy at the moment.

Situation 5

Customer: You recently ordered 15,000 T-shirts from a foreign supplier. They all arrived yesterday but the design on the pocket looks too much like a well-known trademark (you wanted one similar, not the same). Also, there is a small mistake on the invoice.

Supplier: You manufacture cheap T-shirts in a country with low labour costs. As the customer knows, one of the reasons for your success is that your designs are similar to those of well-known brands.

